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# Dongson Drums: Instruments of Shamanism or Regalia?

A New Interpretation of their Decoration may Provide the Answer

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## The drums

A short explanation of what is meant by “Dongson Drums” may be appropriate. Dongson is the name of an ancient dwelling as well as burial site in Thanh-hóa Province, in the southern side of the Red River delta in northern Vietnam. Excavations carried out here in the 1920’s and 30’s, together with the many surface finds previously made in the area, gave a fairly clear picture of what was considered to be the earliest bronze-using civilization in Southeast Asia, which became known as the “Dongson Culture”.<sup>1</sup> Amongst the hundreds of bronze objects found at the site, including axes, spearheads, vessels, ornaments, etc., there were also bronze drums or small replicas of them. It was thus for the first time that such drums had been excavated, rather than to have been found only as chance finds. For drums identical or similar to those excavated at Dongson have been known from all over the Indochinese Peninsula as well as Indonesia for a very long time. News of such strange objects reached Europe in particular during the 19th century to arouse the curiosity of scholars to such an extent that at the turn of the century, when the existence of 165 of these drums was known, a number of books appeared to analyse them. The most seminal of these was that by Heger<sup>2</sup> which classified these drums into four groups (known ever since by the denomination of “Heger I-IV”). Obviously, the Heger-I type is the earliest and we are dealing here only with this particular type (figs. 1 and 2). These drums, then, have been called “one of the most difficult and most important problems of Southeast Asian cultural history”.<sup>3</sup>

However, these drums did not appear in a vacuum. So as to exploit the potential of their interpretation to the fullest, we first have to establish their original cultural and chronological context; this is far from easy.

For the last twenty years or so, Southeast Asian archaeology, and in particular its Bronze Age, has been in a state of turmoil. New theories proposed indeed that bronze was worked here—more precisely in Northeast Thailand—as early the third millennium B.C., thus a thousand years earlier than in China. This was followed by the claim that it was even in the fifth or sixth millennium B.C., which was eventually reduced to a mere early fourth millennium B.C. The media eagerly propagated these sensational dates, as well as their true meaning, namely that therefore the earliest bronze in the world came from Thailand. For millions of people—including a great number of professional archaeologists—this misconception has simply become part of common knowledge.<sup>4</sup>

The implications of this erroneous notion with regard to the study of ancient bronze drums in Southeast Asia are obvious. Soon after the sensational early dates for bronze in northeastern Thailand were made public, a trend developed in neighbouring northern Vietnam, the area in Southeast Asia where the greatest number of the earliest type bronze drums (Heger-I) have been found, to emulate these dates by claiming that a legendary dynasty, starting in the early third millennium B.C., is to be equated with the beginning of bronze in Vietnam. However, there is no clear sign for bronze in Vietnam that is earlier than the turn of the first to the second millennium B.C. But the fact that sophisticated bronze artifacts, such as socketed axes or spear-heads, elaborate bracelets or other items which have often been found in association with the drums, are dated, in this way, to several thousand years earlier in Thailand and up to at least one thousand years earlier in Vietnam, causes some awesome chronological and cultural problems.

If, however, the date for these earliest bronze socketed axes, etc. was brought down to the acceptable level of around 1000 B.C. at the earliest, these problems disappear. The northeastern Thai bronze sites, such as Non Nok Tha, Ban Chiang, Ban Na Di and others, now look increasingly like the local extensions of a bronze-using civilization—and perhaps polity—the centre of which was situated in the northern Vietnam/Yunnan region; on these grounds, such a date would appear quite probable. It would also constitute a *terminus ante quem* for the earliest bronze drums, the Heger-I “Dongson Drums”.

There is also a psychological aspect of the cultural context to be considered. At that time, even much more than at present, Southeast Asian societies lived in a “Vegetal Universe” and produced a “civilization of Vegetal Matter”.<sup>5</sup> In such a civilization of perishable material anything permanent must take on a special significance. We know from the times of the “Indianized Kingdoms” in the area that there was a clear division in architecture between religious monuments which had to be in stone or bricks, and other constructions, including royal palaces, which were in wood, bamboo or other perishable matter. It seems reasonable to assume that in still earlier times from which no buildings or sculptures in stone are known, the introduction of the first large objects (as opposed to small weapons or implements) in bronze, such as the drums, must have caused fascination. This points *a priori* to a ritual-religious use of these drums, rather than a purely utilitarian one.



Fig. 1. A typical Heger-I drum with boat designs on the upper part.  
 National Museum Phnom-Penh, Cambodia.  
 Un tambour Heger-I typique décoré de bateaux sur la partie supérieure.  
 Musée National de Phnom-Penh, Cambodge.  
 (Photo Helmut Loofs-Wissowa).

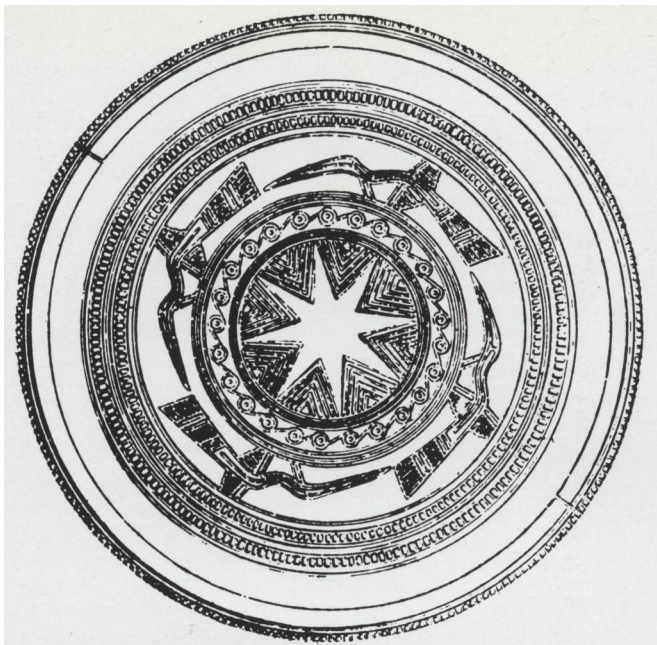


Fig. 2. The tympanum of a typical Heger-I drum from Dongson with the "star" in the centre and flying birds around. Le plateau d'un tambour Heger-I typique de Dôngson montrant « l'étoile » au centre et des oiseaux volant autour. (Photo E.F.E.O.).

## Decoration of the drums

The first attempt to date the drums *absolutely* through the analysis of their decoration was that by the Austrian scholar Robert von Heine-Geldern. He was struck by the resemblance of decoration motifs on the earliest drums with those prominent in certain Bronze or Iron Age cultures in eastern Europe, in particular the Balkans, or even Scandinavia, dating from the end of the second millennium B.C. to about 700 B.C. As these similarities were matched by others in such widely different fields as musical instruments and shipbuilding, for instance, Heine-Geldern eventually felt justified in postulating his by now almost infamous theory of the "Pontic Migration", i.e. that there must have been a movement of people from eastern Europe to Southeast and East Asia, to transmit these decoration motifs.<sup>6</sup> As controversial as it may be, this theory has at least the merit of putting a date to the earliest drums, namely that of the 8th century B.C., corresponding to the conquest of the Chou capital Hao by "Western Barbarians" in 771 B.C., which contrasted sharply with the widely held opinion that the drums could only have been as old as the 3rd or 4th century B.C. Heine-Geldern's chronological assumptions received encouragement from the find, not far from Kuala Lumpur, of two Heger-I drums set on a thick wooden plank (in the form of a boat!), covered by a mound, which could therefore be carbon-dated: to the fifth century B.C.<sup>7</sup>

What Heine-Geldern did *not* say was that the knowledge of bronze-working itself was thus transmitted from eastern Europe to eastern Asia, nor that the form or conception of the drums originated in Europe. It is quite clear that the drums themselves must be an indigenous product of the people in the northern Indochinese Peninsula/southern China area, although their decoration may have been partly influenced by the West.

Therefore, the recent find of what seems to be a small clay model of a Heger-I drum in the Red River Valley, dated to ca. 850 B.C.,<sup>8</sup> in no way disproves the Pontic Migration theory, but only adds another century or so to the antiquity of this type of drum (figs. 3 and 4). Unfortunately, no indication of any decoration could be seen on this small (9 cm wide) model. Moreover, Heine-Geldern stated categorically that the population movement he envisaged was not a once-only migration, but a series of movements drawn out over *several centuries*. It seems to be nonsensical thus to pin this author down to a particular date and to argue that, because a drum or a decoration



Fig. 3. Small clay model of a Heger-I drum discovered in the Red River valley and dated to ab. 850 B.C. Modèle réduit en terre cuite d'un tambour Heger-I découvert dans la vallée de la Rivière Rouge et daté d'environ 850 avant J.-C. (Photo Helmut Loofs-Wissowa).



Fig. 4. A Heger-I drum discovered 1978 near Thanh-hoa, Vietnam, for comparison. Thanh-hoa Provincial Museum. Par comparaison, un tambour Heger-I découvert en 1978 près de Thanh-hoa, Vietnam. Musée Provincial du Thanh-hoa. (Photo Helmut Loofs-Wissowa).

motif has been found in Vietnam a century or so earlier than the eighth century B.C., the entire theory of there having been a transmission of decoration motifs or ideas from Eastern Europe to Southeast Asia cannot be trusted.

Another widespread misconception is that *all* decoration motifs on the drums were postulated to have been introduced from the west. A closer examination of the decoration of Dongson drums reveals that it is only the geometrical motifs (tangent-circles, ladder-motif, meander and possibly the hatched triangle, etc.) the origin of which can be traced to eastern Europe. Although they are frequent enough to be seen as "typical" for these drums, they are of no importance as far as the evaluation of their purpose is concerned.

## Interpretations of decoration motifs

The most striking and characteristic decoration motifs are without doubt the central "star", the long-tailed flying bird on the tympanum of all Heger-I drums, and the more or less stylized depictions of boats on the bulging upper part of a great number of them. Neither of these essential decorative elements owes its existence to an outside influence. A brief evaluation of each of them in turn may in fact yield the key to the understanding of the essence of the meaning of Heger-I drums.

### The Central "Star"

To all scholars who first dealt with the drums, Austrian, German, Dutch and French—all steeped in the Judaeo-Christian tradition—there was no doubt that the only decorative motif common to all drums, that in the centre of the tympanum, represented a star or may be the sun; their main preoccupation was with the number of "rays" this star or sun could have. Nobody ever questioned this assumption and quite fantastic and consequential theories were built upon the star or sun theory. Even the most recent survey of Southeast Asian drums,<sup>9</sup> still refers to this motif as the "solar star", whatever that may mean.

The theory that the central motif on the Dongson drums must be the sun was first proposed by van der Hoop in 1932, but put in a more coherent conceptual form only some years later by Colani who argues for this motif to be the sun because of the many "solar" symbols surrounding it; taking as example the Ngoc-lu drum, she sees in the three concentric circles of creatures around "the divine Heavenly body": men, obviously dancing a sun-dance, deer, whose fawn-coloured fur dedicates them to the sun, and sun-birds, "all enthusiastically worship the Sovereign who engenders universal life".<sup>10</sup> In support of this interpretation Colani quotes Déchelette who discovered a number of solar symbols from Central and Western Europe which apparently could be matched to those on Dongson

Fig. 5. Tympanum of one of the two drums found near Kuala Lumpur, dated to the 5th century B.C. National Museum Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia. Le plateau d'un des deux tambours trouvés près de Kuala Lumpur, datés au 5<sup>e</sup> siècle avant J.-C. Musée National de Kuala Lumpur, Malaisie. (Photo Helmut Loofs-Wissowa).



drums, including the central “sun” motif. Colani therefore concludes<sup>11</sup> that there must have been a vast area of solar cult, stretching from Southeast Asia far into the West, with the representation of the sun as a many-pointed “star” originating in Southeast Asia. In the light of what follows, this is simply impossible. Moreover, the idea that there ever was a sun-cult in an area like Southeast Asia, the fertility of which depends on the monsoon rains and where the sun is normally seen as something to be avoided, is difficult to entertain. Also how could one imagine the central part of the tympanum of these drums to be the sun, if this obviously was the part to be beaten (fig. 5): do you *beat* the object of your cult?

Probably the most seminal hypothesis based on the star-theory is that elaborated by Quaritch Wales.<sup>12</sup> Being struck by the coincidence of the distribution of Shamanism and that of what he saw as “Dongson influences”, Wales constructed a model of an association of Shamanism with the Dongson Culture and went as far as to say that Shamanism was *the* Dongson religion. Pursuing his argument, he conceded that on the Malay Peninsula, in Sumatra and in Java this Dongson influence had been displaced by Hinduism and eventually Islam, and that, therefore, those areas not much touched by these religious influences, such as Borneo, preserve an almost pure Dongson-type culture.

In support of this theory, Wales argued that not only was the central motif on the tympanum of the drums the representation of a star — and not of the sun as had previously been supposed — but more specifically of the Pole Star, marking the centre of the sky: through it passes the axis of the universe through which the shaman gains access to the heavens. This “star” on the bronze drums, in other words, is to be seen as the final proof that shamanism was something akin to an “official” religion in Dongson-influenced Southeast Asia, from northern Vietnam into eastern Indonesia.

There are so many objections to the acceptance of this theory that it is impossible to deal with all of them in a short article. Put under the three headings of (a) concordance of the extension of shamanism with that of Dongson influence, (b) use of drums by shamans, and (c) interpretation of the central motif of the bronze drums as a star or even the Pole Star, let alone the sun, the following objections or observations may be singled out as most relevant.

- (a) Shamanism is basically a religious complex in the culture of the peoples of Siberia and northern Central Asia; it is doubtful whether certain religious manifestations, comprising elements of this complex, in other parts of the world can legitimately be called by the same name and be related in any way to the original Siberian shamanism.<sup>13</sup>
  - There do not seem to have been any relations between Siberia and the northern part of the Indochinese Peninsula 3000 years ago which could explain an influence of Dongson on Siberia or *vice versa*.
  - The basis of shamanism, as Wales points out himself, is the cosmology of pastoral nomads. There are no pastoral nomads in Southeast Asia.
  - In true shamanistic symbolism, the *horse* plays an important, almost essential rôle. The horse does not, with very few exceptions, appear on Southeast Asian (as opposed to some Yunnanese) bronze drums and is, moreover, absent from the symbolism of the Dayaks whom Wales cites as practising Dongson-inspired shamanism.
  - In much of the area influenced by Dongson — notably in eastern Indonesia, including Borneo — the Pole Star is not visible and its significance is unknown.



Fig. 6. Tunguse shamans beating portable drums.  
Chamans toungous battant des tambours portatifs.  
(After/d'après Hugo A. Bernatzik, *Die Grosse Völkerkunde*, vol. 2, p. 61, fig. 42 [Leipzig, 1939]).

- (b) Shamans generally use tambourines or gongs, rather than drums. If at all used, the latter are made, as Wales states repeatedly, of a wooden frame of birch (a sacred tree in Siberian lore); in any case, these instruments must be light enough to be carried around and beaten by the dancing shaman (fig. 6).
  - Obviously, the shaman cannot lift up a heavy bronze drum of the Heger-I type and dance around with it, beating it. Bronze drums, therefore, cannot have been used in shamanistic rituals.
  - The fact of being made of metal, rather than of organic material disqualifies these drums from shamanic use anyway.
  - There are no birch trees in Southeast Asia, neither are there depictions of them, or of any other “Tree of Life”, on the drums.
  - Drums do not seem to be mentioned in reports on Bornean shamanism.
  - Apart from the Philippines, the island of Borneo is the only major area of Southeast Asia from which no bronze drums (of whatever type) have been discovered.
- (c) I have stated elsewhere in some detail why the assumption that the central motif on the tympana of Heger-I type bronze drums represents a star is untenable.<sup>14</sup> All I can do here is to briefly repeat the main arguments.
  - The identification of this motif as a star is due only to the cultural background of those researchers who first investigated and wrote about these drums.
  - To this day, nobody in rural, non-westernized Vietnam, Laos or Burma would recognize in this motif a star, nor would he/she, if asked to draw a star, use the multi-branched symbol: a dot or a simple circle would do.



Fig. 7. Babylonian boundary stone (kudurru), 2nd millennium B.C., showing Venus, moon and sun.  
Borne babylonienne (kudurru) du II<sup>e</sup> millénaire avant J.-C., montrant Vénus, lune et soleil.

- There is no reason to believe that people in the northern part of the Indochinese Peninsula 3000 years ago would have chosen this symbol to represent a star, let alone to recognize it as such if they saw it.
- Earliest pictorial representations of the sun or stars (including planets) in ancient Mesopotamia, India and China indeed consisted only of a disk or a circle. If there were any rays at all, straight, wavy or in the form of elongated triangles, they would project outward from such a disk (fig. 7). This is also true of even earlier (Neolithic) representations of the sun (fig. 8) and, further afield, of those of stars in present New Guinea (fig. 9) which seem to show a curious resemblance. That the sun in the flag of Taiwan is also represented in a similar way, *i.e.* with triangular rays projecting from a disk, is a truism. Never has the sun or a star been represented by rays or branches alone, leaving the centre “empty” as it were. It is not clear where this now generally accepted symbol of a “star” comes from, which in its five-branched variety has become the national emblem of not only the USA and the USSR but also, paradoxically, of China, Vietnam and virtually every Southeast Asian country, from Burma to Indonesia. It does not seem to have anything to do with a star, but probably derives from the Pythagorean symbol of the five-element theory or that of the Hand of Fatimah!
- In reality, this “star”-shaped motif on the tympana of Dongson drums is not a motif at all: it is a left-over. To explain this, one has to look at the mechanics of decorating a circular surface. The most likely way of doing this is to use concentric bands or fields and to fill them with certain motifs. Toward the centre there comes a time when, instead of having another ring, there is just an open disk. If equilateral or isosceles triangles—a prominent motif in Dongson decoration—are put inside this space with their bases to the circle delimiting it and the points turned inwards, then inevitably a “star”-shaped space is left in the centre. But this “star” is only an unintentional “passive” motif.

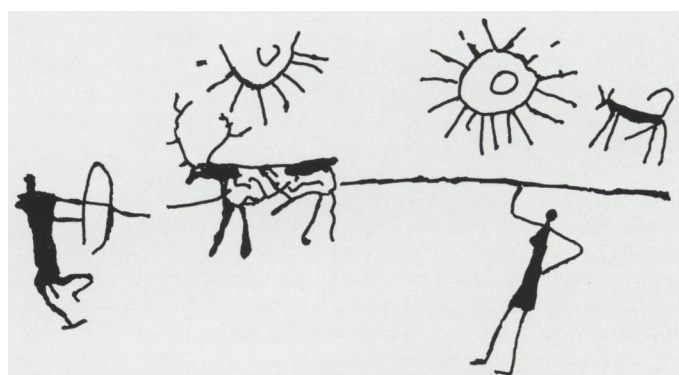


Fig. 8. Neolithic hunting scene on a stone slab from Burzahom, Kashmir.  
Scène de chasse, gravure sur pierre néolithique de Burzahom, Cachemire.  
Redrawn from/redessiné d'après Asian Perspectives, vol. XIV (1971, publ. 1973), p. 135.

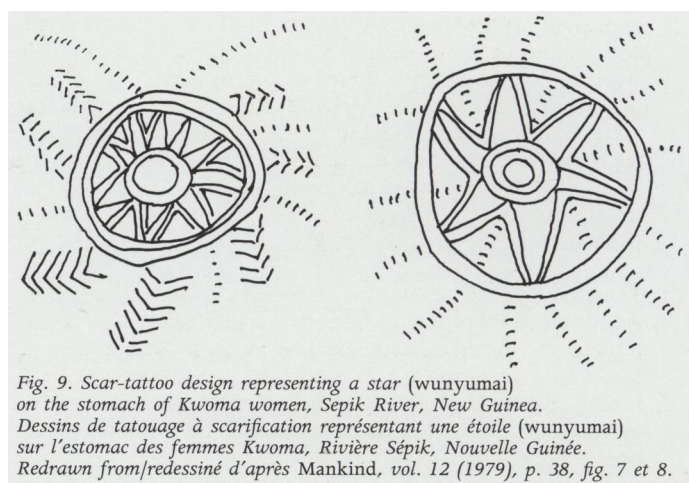


Fig. 9. Scar-tattoo design representing a star (wunyumai) on the stomach of Kwoma women, Sepik River, New Guinea.  
Dessins de tatouage à scarification représentant une étoile (wunyumai) sur l'estomac des femmes Kwoma, Rivière Sépik, Nouvelle Guinée.  
Redrawn from/redessiné d'après Mankind, vol. 12 (1979), p. 38, fig. 7 et 8.

Proof of this theory is found in the fact that the same decorative *ensemble* of concentric circles with hatched equilateral triangles pointing inwards leaving a rather large “star” in the centre, is also found on the lids of Dongson bronze containers where this “star”-motif cannot have any symbolic meaning and cannot be associated with shamanism or any other cult or ritual. Furthermore, in cases where the triangles around the “star” on bronze drums are not simply hatched, their usually otherwise elaborate decoration also shows that they, the triangles, are the “active” decorative element and not the left-over “star”. In his recent survey of bronze drums A. J. Bernet Kempers,<sup>15</sup> calls these triangles “interradial designs” which obviously is the wrong way of putting it: it is the triangles which produce the “rays”, not the other way round.

To conclude this section and to answer the question whether shamanism may have been the religion of Dongson and shamans the priests of that polity, we can only state that nothing whatsoever in the form or decoration of the bronze drums supports this theory.

Having thus eliminated the notion, based on the erroneous interpretation of the central motif, that a sun-cult or shamanism was in any significant way linked with the bronze drums as a valid working hypothesis, we now have to search for a more likely alternative and to tackle the problem of what could have been the religious or ritual significance of the drums at the time when they suddenly appeared in the early or middle first millennium B.C., as they obviously were no ordinary utilitarian objects or musical instruments. (It has to be kept in mind, however, that “sudden”, in this context, still could mean a couple or more centuries—and thus many generations—during which time important developments and changes may have taken place). Unfortunately, this complex question is not one which can be answered adequately in a short article. All we can do here is to summarize the main elements to help us in this endeavour; they are, apart from rare literary evidence in Chinese writings to which we shall revert later, only three: (a) the present meaning of bronze drums in societies which still use them, (b) the distribution of Heger-I type drums throughout Southeast Asia, and (c) the interpretation of the other two most prominent decoration motifs on them, apart from the ubiquitous non-star in the centre of the tympanum, namely the birds and the boats.

- (a) So much has been written about this topic that it is well-nigh impossible to even summarize the many opinions expressed. Suffice it to say that virtually every interpretation includes a component of wealth, power, fertility or the afterlife. But then, most, if not all, drums at present “used” in any way in Southeast Asian societies, such as amongst the Karen in Burma, or being in royal collections or monasteries in Thailand, Laos or Cambodia, are of the much later Heger-III type and their perceived value need not necessarily reflect correctly the value attached to Heger-I drums more than 2000 years earlier.<sup>16</sup>
- (b) The distribution of Heger-I drums throughout Southeast Asia, on the other hand, gives us a much better clue to the understanding of the significance of these drums if it is taken into account that those found in Indonesia are not locally manufactured but almost certainly come from the Mainland, presumably the northern part of the Indochinese Peninsula.<sup>17</sup>

- This latter assumption is also strongly supported by the virtual uniformity of the decoration on the drums wherever they are found, from temperate northern Vietnam to tropical Indonesia, which in no way reflects variations in fauna, flora or technology throughout this vast region, spanning several climatic zones; on the whole this decoration clearly has a “northern” character although there may be the occasional, perhaps “custom-made”, decoration of a different type.
- Based on another assumption, namely that the drums were—at least in the beginning—bestowed emblems of legitimate power, I developed some years ago (and after long discussions with my Vietnamese colleagues) the “Regalia Theory” which, in essence, postulates that there could not have been trade in these emblems, but that they could only have been bestowed by a religious or ritual authority to chiefs deemed to be worthy of this honour or actively seeking it.<sup>18</sup> This was to replace the two other theories seeking to explain the wide distribution of the drums, the generally accepted “Trade Theory” and the less widespread but still occasionally encountered “Migration Theory”, which are both untenable on archaeological grounds.

- (c) The analysis of the two obviously indigenous decoration motifs on the drums, the birds and the boats, seems to support the theory that the drums emanated from an authority that was by definition concerned with the well-being of a particular community and, perhaps, with the spread of these notions further afield, not for political, but more religious reasons.

### The Birds

It has been argued that the long-beaked and long-tailed birds with out-stretched wings on the tympanum of Heger-I type drums are to be seen in connection with the central solar star with which they are locked in a symbolic association having its origin probably somewhere in the Near East.<sup>19</sup> The birds are usually described as aquatic ones, cranes, swans, storks or, most likely, herons.

Now, while there is a vague resemblance with scenes of herons (or other birds) walking or flying around a swastika on ceramic bowls from Mesopotamia as old as the 4th millennium B.C., it seems somewhat daring to transplant this entire symbolic *ensemble* into the totally different cultural and climatic area of Southeast Asia 3000 years later—especially when it is not fully proven that the swastika really stood for the sun in 4th millennium B.C. Mesopotamia and it is impossible that the central “star” on the drums stood for the sun in 1st millennium B.C. Southeast Asia! Things just do not fit. They also do not fit if another, similar interpretation is adopted, namely that the birds are phoenixes greeting the morning sun or the “Viet Race’s Pheasant Flying In Accordance with the Sun Direction”, as mentioned in an undated but presumably post-13th cent. A.D. Vietnamese text.<sup>20</sup> If these birds were supposed to “greet” the sun or to “fly in the direction of the sun”, one would expect them to be represented with their heads turned *towards* the centre of the tympanum (i.e. the “sun”), rather than flying passively *around* it. How can one imagine birds to fly *around* the sun anyway?

However, an important notion can be retained from this textual mention, namely that this bird is seen as symbolizing the Viet ethnic group. This bird could thus be the totemic ani-



Fig. 10. The Vietnamese "totemic" bird being used as emblem of the Vietnamese Cultural Centre in Bonn, Germany.

*L'oiseau «totémique» vietnamien utilisé comme emblème du centre culturel vietnamien à Bonn, Allemagne.*

(Photo Helmut Loofs-Wissowa).

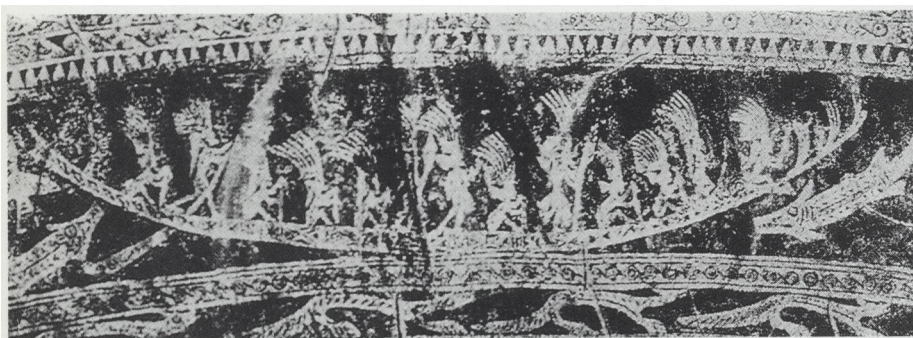


Fig. 11. Representation of a boat with people standing on a Heger-I drum.  
*Représentation d'une pirogue avec des hommes debout sur un tambour Heger-I.*  
After/d'après Wen Yu, Selected Ancient Bronze Drums Found in China and Southeast Asia (Shanghai, 1955).

mal of the Vietnamese. This is also borne out by its present name throughout Vietnam: *chim* (bird) *Lac*, the kingdom of Au Lac being the first historical attested Viet kingdom and the name Lac being the earliest ethnic name of the Vietnamese. No wonder that now, at time of reassertion of a Vietnamese identity, it has almost achieved the rank of a national symbol or a heraldic state image, similar to the American eagle or other such heraldic birds (fig. 10). That such a symbol, which it seems to have been as far back in Vietnamese history as can be documented, figures prominently on the "regalia" bestowed by a ritual authority situated in precisely the area which saw the growth of a Viet nation and polity, seems more acceptable than to see in it the remnants of a Mesopotamian symbolism of several thousand years earlier. The fact that this bird is the only figurative decoration element to appear on virtually *all* Heger-I drums must surely lend some credence to this assumption.

But there are many more questions connected with the birds which must be asked, although they cannot yet be satisfactorily answered. For instance, what bird is it whose feathers are worn on the head-dress of the "bird-men" on many of the drums? They are rather long and could therefore well be from the long-tailed birds on the tympana. Thus, could there be a connection between these "bird-men" and the "totemic bird" mentioned above? As this bird is almost certainly an aquatic one, could there not be an association with fertility again, based on the role of water in Southeast Asia? Let us not forget that Dongson site itself is situated on a river. Moreover, there is at least one instance of an unequivocal link of a powerful fertility symbol (coitus) with the birds, on the lid of the bronze vase of *Đào-thinh*. One could also ask oneself why the stork, obviously also an aquatic bird, is so closely connected with fertility in European folk-lore and why the ibis was sacred in Egypt?

### The Boats

In practically all interpretations dealing with the meaning of these boats (which only appear on at the most 20 % of the Southeast Asian Heger-I drums) a connection with the afterlife, the transport of the dead to their final destination or with ideas concerning Totality and Holy Life in general is assumed and the similarity with present Bornean or Sumatran symbolic representations is stressed.<sup>21</sup> But if it is taken into account that, as has been mentioned earlier, the Indonesian drums have not been made locally and that their decoration is also clearly deri-

Fig. 12. Boat race on the Mekong.  
*Course de pirogues sur le Mékong.*  
After/d'après Charles Archaimbault, La course de pirogues au Laos (Ascona, 1972), fig. 29.



ved from the Mainland, might one not more profitably look for resemblances with cultural elements, present or past, on the Indochinese Peninsula?

One such element, widespread throughout the area, are the ritual boat-races on large rivers, which are to this day part of elaborate rituals to procure fertility for the realm, presided over by the king (or ruler), and which obviously have a very long history.<sup>22</sup> Here again, their depiction would not be out of place on the emblem of power of the king, whose main duty it presumably was to guarantee precisely this fertility.

Several observations support this theory. The boats on the drums look much more like river-boats than sea-going vessels. They have no out-riggers like most Indonesian boats. If one thinks in terms of transport of the dead or their souls to a destination across the sea, one would expect this to be done in ships with sails: nobody *rows* across open water! Moreover, everybody would be sitting down, whereas there are always some people standing up in the boats on the drums—just like in boat-races a present (figs. 11 and 12).

The possibility that the depiction of boats could be connected with the transport of the “regalia” (*i.e.* drums) to areas of Southeast Asia beyond the Indochinese Peninsula, must also be considered.<sup>23</sup> The fact that the Kuala Lumpur drums stood on a plank *in form of a boat* (see above) also points in this direction.

## Conclusions

Taking all the above observations into consideration, it seems reasonable to conclude that there is little chance that neither a sun-cult nor shamanism was prevalent or even “official” in Dongson times. The available evidence rather points to the existence of a network of socio-ritual connections throughout Southeast Asia, centred around an authority, somewhere in the north of the Indochinese Peninsula (but not necessarily in Dongson itself) which could be imagined as something similar to the Papacy in the Occident which for centuries bestowed crowns but did not rule politically.

We might thus imagine the coming and going of embassies or missions from tribal chiefs in various parts of Southeast Asia who through the obtaining of a drum would seek to become kings in the then accepted sense of the term and thus be integrated into a wider politico-religious system, transcending their own relatively limited one. Or, alternatively, we may imagine the sending of emissaries from the “Holy See” to take these drums to far-away places for the same purpose.<sup>24</sup>

Looking at the question of the use of so-called Dongson Drums in this way, *i.e.* by first eliminating what they cannot have been and then, according to a well-known saying by Sherlock Holmes, accepting what is left as the truth, we see that it is the birds and the boats on their decoration which tell us more about the political Facts of Life of Bronze Age Southeast Asia than any other item of material culture of this time. What they seem to tell us is that the drums which they adorn were the regalia of local chiefs who asked for these to be bestowed upon them so as to become part of a network of politics according to the then-prevailing concepts of kingship, not unlike the “Indianized” States in the area some centuries later. Perhaps it is also significant that the only two major areas of Southeast Asia never to have experienced any genuine Indianization, the island of Borneo (Kalimantan) and the Philippines, are also the only parts of that vast region where no such bronze drums

have been found. Thus, as has recently been pointed out by an eminent Indologist, the development of chiefdoms indicated by the drums may well have continued smoothly, though accelerated, under Indian influence.<sup>25</sup> As the Indian concept of kingship also includes the responsibility of the king for the fertility of his realm, this would indicate the continuity of ethical values from “prehistory” into history “proper” and would explain the apparent easiness with which this Indian influence was accepted in Southeast Asia. Looking at the “regalia” expressing these values, *i.e.* the drums, we see that they, too, remained essentially the same over the long time-span from their first appearance to the beginnings of Indian influence — just as the crown, sceptre and globe of Charlemagne are still now the regalia of European kings in very much the same form, in spite of dramatic political changes in the meantime, although they have lost much of their original significance.

To finish, let us briefly return to the above-mentioned rare allusions to the drums in ancient Chinese texts. The best known of these concerns the Chinese general Ma Yuan who was sent to put down the 40-43 A.D. uprising of the Trung sisters in Chiao-chih (northern Vietnam), which had become a Chinese protectorate in 111 B.C., and to annex it fully to the Han empire. His most significant act in pursuing this aim was the confiscation and destruction of the bronze drums of the local chieftains, thereby depriving the latter of the signs of their political power.<sup>26</sup> The production of Heger-I drums seems to have ceased shortly thereafter anyway. However, the tradition of these drums being considered signs for legitimate political power clearly survives in the area to this day. The victory ceremonies over the Chinese who had tried to occupy Vietnam again in the early 15th century were accompanied by the beating of bronze drums,<sup>27</sup> and (recent) paintings in the Cham Museum, Danang, show Viet troops fighting to the sounds of what looks like Heger-I drums (fig. 13) — a rather curious parallel to Yunnanese warriors fighting with such a drum at their feet (fig. 14), echoing in turn the well-known representations of warriors carrying such drums on the Pasemah stones, Sumatra. Drums in royal (or former royal) collections throughout Southeast Asia mentioned earlier, may point in the same direction. There is also the use of the drums rulers of Vietnam, no doubt to further



Fig. 13. Viet troops fighting to the sounds of a bronze drum in the 15th century. Recent painting in the Cham Museum, Danang, Vietnam.  
Les combattants Viêt s'en vont à la guerre au son d'un tambour de bronze au x<sup>e</sup> siècle. Tableau récent au Musée Cham, Danang, Vietnam.  
(Photo Justin Jordens).

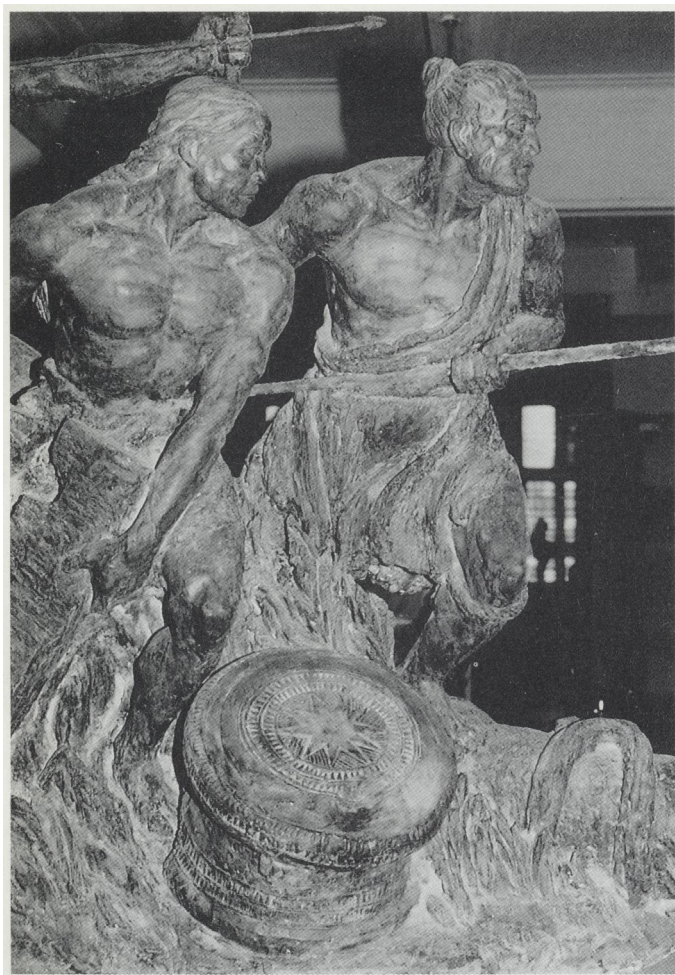


Fig. 14. Bronze sculpture of warriors with a Heger-I drum at their feet in the Yunnan Provincial Museum, Kunming, China.  
Sculpture en bronze de guerriers avec un tambour Heger-I à leurs pieds au Musée Provincial du Yunnan, Kunming, Chine.  
(Photo Helmut Loofs-Wissowa).

legitimize their power, with the frequent depiction of Ho Chi Minh next to such a drum and the revealing poster to celebrate the 50th anniversary of the Indochinese Communist Party showing the tympanum of a Dongson drum on which some decoration motifs have been radically changed but, significantly, the birds have been retained (fig. 15). One could perhaps call this a clear case of *plus ça change*...—and that over a period of more than 3000 years!



Fig. 15. Giant poster in Ho Chi Minh City celebrating the 50th anniversary of the Indochinese Communist Party. Affiche géante à Ho Chi Minh-Ville célébrant le cinquantenaire du Parti Communiste Indochinois.  
(Photo David Marr).

1. For a description of the site and its finds see Olov R. T. Janse, *Archaeological Research in Indo-China*, vol. III: *The Ancient Dwelling-Site of Đông-sôn (Than-Hóa, Annam)* (Bruges, 1958) and L. Bezacier, *Le Viêt-Nam* (Paris 1972), pp. 82-247.
2. Franz Heger, *Alte Metalltrommeln aus Südost-Asien* (Leipzig, 1902).
3. Robert Heine-Geldern, "Bedeutung und Herkunft der ältesten hinterindischen Metalltrommeln (Kesselgongs)", *Asia Major*, VIII, 1933, p. 536. The number of scholarly writings on these drums has in the meantime reached hundreds.
4. For more details see H. H. E. Loofs-Wissowa, "The Development and Spread of Metallurgy in Southeast Asia: A Review of the Present Evidence", *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, XIV, 1983, pp. 1-11. The fact that these inflated dates have been very unobtrusively disowned, many years ago, by their original instigator who, however, still clings to the claim of a third-millennium B.C. antiquity for early bronze in Thailand (Wilhelm G. Solheim II, "The Dating of Sites and Phases in Northeastern Thailand", *Journal of the Hong Kong Archaeological Society*, X, 1982-83, publ. 1984, pp. 112-116), is of little solace, as it is painfully clear that it is almost impossible to eliminate the notion that the "Cradle of Civiliza-

tion" stood in Thailand from textbooks or official publications, let alone the more popular press; it certainly is still very much believed in 1991.

5. A concept introduced and elaborated by the French geographer Pierre Gourou.

6. Robert Heine-Geldern, "Das Tocharerproblem und die Pontische Wanderung", *Saeculum*, II, 1951, pp. 225-255.

7. B. A. V. Peacock, "The Drums of Kampong Sungai Lang", *Malaya in History*, X, 1965, pp. 3-15. In this context, it is not at all clear to me why an eminent researcher into Southeast Asian archaeology should want to reduce this date, while at the same time advocating the acceptance of an illogically high date for bronze, based on the same dating technique, in neighbouring Thailand (Wilhelm G. Solheim II, "The Development of Metallurgy in Southeast Asia: Another Reply to Loofs-Wissowa", *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, XIV, 1983, p. 19).

8. This date was given to me by my Vietnamese colleagues in 1978, but there was no way of checking on it. See also H. H. E. Loofs-Wissowa, "The Distribution of Dongson Drums: some Thoughts", Peter Snoy (ed.), *Ethnologie und Geschichte* (Wiesbaden, 1983), pl. XXVIII.

9. A. J. Bernet Kempers, *The Kettledrums of Southeast Asia* (Rotterdam, 1988). The late Prof.

Pham Huy Thông, in his "Introduction" (pp. 262-271) to *Dong Son Drums in Vietnam* (Hanoi, 1990), also calls this motif a "multi-rayed solar star", but this was written before the publication of Bernet Kempers' book.

10. Madeleine Colani, "Vestiges d'un culte solaire en Indochine", *Institut Indochinois pour l'Étude de l'Homme: Bulletin et Travaux pour 1940, 1941*, pp. 37-39. Prof. Thông, *ibid.* (n. 9), follows Colani by saying that the central motif, formerly interpreted as a star, "must now be corrected to mean the Solar Star, the center of our universe" (p. 268) and that therefore the drums are depicting ideas of cosmology.

11. *Ibid.*, p. 40.

12. H. G. Quaritch Wales, *Prehistory and Religion in South-East Asia* (London, 1952), p. 65-108.

13. Laszlo Vajda, "Zur phaseologischen Stellung des Schamanismus", C. A. Schmitz (ed.), *Religions-Ethnologie* (Frankfurt a. M., 1964), pp. 265-295.

14. H. H. E. Loofs, "Dongson Drums and Heavenly Bodies," Noel Barnard (ed.), *Ancient Chinese Bronzes and Southeast Asian Metal and Other Archaeological Artifacts* (Melbourne, 1976), pp. 441-467. An updated French version of this article is being published in *Asie du Sud-Est et Monde Insulindien* (Paris) under the title "Les tambours de bronze (dits de Đông-són) et les astres".

15. A. J. Bernet Kempers, *The Kettledrums of Southeast Asia* (Rotterdam, 1988), pp. 118-120.

16. See in particular Éveline Porée-Maspero, "Mythes du déluge et tambours de bronze", *IV<sup>e</sup> Congrès Int. des Sciences Anthropologiques et ethnologiques*, Vienne 1952, vol. II, 1<sup>re</sup> partie, pp. 246-249, and *Étude sur les rites agraires des Cambodgiens*, vol. II (Paris, 1964), pp. 417-421.

17. This point was again recently confirmed in conversation with Prof. Wolfgang Marschall, author of "Metallurgie und frühe Besiedelungsgeschichte Indonesiens", *Ethnologica*, 4 (Cologne, 1968), pp. 29-263, where he emphasized it in the first place (p. 48).

18. H. H. E. Loofs-Wissowa, "The Distribution of Dongson Drums: Some Thoughts", Peter Snoy (ed.), *Ethnologie und Geschichte: Festschrift für Karl Jettmar* (Wiesbaden, 1983), pp. 410-417, pl. XXVIII.

19. A. J. Bernet Kempers, *The Kettledrums of Southeast Asia*, pp. 170-172.

20. This information is gleaned from an anonymous, undated—but obviously fairly recent—glossy poster, "Printed in USA", depicting the tympanum of the Ngoc-lu drum and giving "Explanations About Brass [sic] Drums". See also W. Lineham, "The Significance of the Scenes on the Ancient Bronze Drums", *J. Mal. Br. Roy. As. Soc.*, XXIV, 1951, pp. 29-56.

21. A. J. Bernet Kempers, *The Kettledrums of Southeast Asia*, pp. 143-163. See also Alfred Steinmann, *Das kultische Schiff in Indonesien* (Zürich, 1939).

22. Charles Archambault, *La course de pirogues au Laos* (Ascona, 1972). In her *Rites agraires des Cambodgiens*, vol. II, pp. 417-421, Éveline Porée-Maspero drew already attention to the possibility of these boats being those of ritual boat races, without however suggesting a connection between these depictions and the fact that it is on behalf of the king, responsible for the fertility of the realm, that the boat races are held. In this connection it may be interesting to note that the apparently naked helmsman of such a boat on a Heger-I drum in the Yunnan Provincial Museum, Kunming, is clearly shown in an ithyphallic state.

23. H. H. E. Loofs-Wissowa, "The Distribution of Dongson Drums", p. 415.

24. *Ibid.*, p. 414.

25. Hermann Kulke, "Indian Colonies, Indianization or Cultural Convergence?", *Onderzoek in Zuidoost-Asië* (Leiden, 1990), p. 19.

26. As mentioned in Ma Yuan's biography in the *Hou-Han shu chu*, 54. See Lo Hsiang-lin, "The Yüeh Bronze Drums, their Manufacture and Use", F. S. Drake (ed.), *Historical, Archaeological and Linguistic Studies* (Hong Kong, 1967), pp. 110-114; see also also Léon Vandermeersch,

"Bronze Kettledrums of South-East Asia", *Journal of Oriental Studies*, 3, 1956, pp. 291-298 and Jennifer Holmgren, *Chinese Colonisation of Northern Vietnam* (Canberra, 1980), pp. 16-21.

27. Lê Thành Khôi, *Le Viêt-Nam* (Paris, 1955), p. 81.

## Les Tambours de Đôngson : instruments chamaniques ou Regalia ?

Une nouvelle interprétation de leur décoration pourrait donner la réponse

Les tambours de bronze du type Heger-I, appelés maintenant communément « de Đôngson » d'après le site de ce nom au nord du Viêt Nam, toujours richement décorés, ont été trouvés partout en Asie du Sud-Est, du nord de la péninsule indochinoise jusqu'à l'est de l'Indonésie, sauf sur l'île de Bornéo et aux Philippines. L'âge des plus anciens de ces grands tambours n'est pas certain mais il doit être d'environ 2500 ans. Ce qui n'est pas certain non plus est leur fonction et la raison de leur dispersion. Plusieurs théories ont été émises sur ces deux points, notamment, à propos du premier, que ces tambours étaient des instruments chamaniques et, quant au second, que leur dispersion est simplement due aux échanges commerciaux.

La décoration de ces tambours, tout en étant assez variée, comprend trois éléments que l'on trouve sur tous, ou sur une grande partie d'entre eux : l'« étoile » au centre du plateau, des oiseaux en vol également sur le plateau, et des bateaux plus ou moins stylisés sur l'épave. Il est démontré ici que l'« étoile » centrale ne peut être ni une étoile ni le soleil et que les théories

concernant l'emploi de ces tambours basées sur l'une ou l'autre de ces interprétations sont dénuées de tout fondement. L'une de ces théories veut que les tambours aient été des instruments d'un chamanisme officiel à Đôngson.

La vraie raison de la distribution actuelle des tambours de Đôngson peut être déduite de deux faits ou suppositions : les tambours ont été initialement utilisés pour l'investiture d'un roi et ceux trouvés en Indonésie n'ont pas été fabriqués localement mais quelque part dans le nord de l'Indochine. Ces tambours, donc, sont comme des regalia. Leur dispersion ne peut s'expliquer que par le désir de chefs lointains de devenir rois en obtenant un grand tambour de bronze de l'Autorité rituelle (mais non politique) située quelque part dans le nord de la péninsule indochinoise qui avait le pouvoir, comme la papauté dans l'Occident, de donner des regalia. Une nouvelle interprétation du motif des oiseaux et de celui des bateaux soutient cette théorie.